

Pioneer launches BDXL drive

Pioneer launched the BDR-206MBK, a optical disc writer which can support up to 128GB optical media

TB drives by end of 2011

Better disk densities might result in 4 to 5TB 3.5-inch desktop by the end of the year

Nvidia launches GeForce GTX 570, AMD Radeon HD 6900 series

Things are very hot again in the two sided world of discrete graphics cards, with Nvidia and AMD releasing rival products in quick succession. After the GTX 580 and Radeon HD 6800 series launches recently, Nvidia followed up the festivities and accompanying price drops by releasing the GTX 570, priced at around ₹22,000. So far, the single-GPU card is pegged ahead of both the GTX

480 and HD 5870. It is based on the same GF110 architecture as the GTX 580, with a little less of everything.

As you can expect with the newer architecture, the GTX 570 offers better performance at lower heat (using the 580's vapour-cooling system) and power consumption, apart from offering more choice at the top-end of the market.

The card also apparently offers great overclocking headroom, and some factory overclocked versions offer 810MHz core clock and 1620MHz shader clock and 3960MHz memory clock speeds out of the box.

The DX11 GeForce GTX 570 is interestingly positioned in terms of hardware, falling in between the GTX 480 and GTX 480, though it has the GF110's more efficient design.

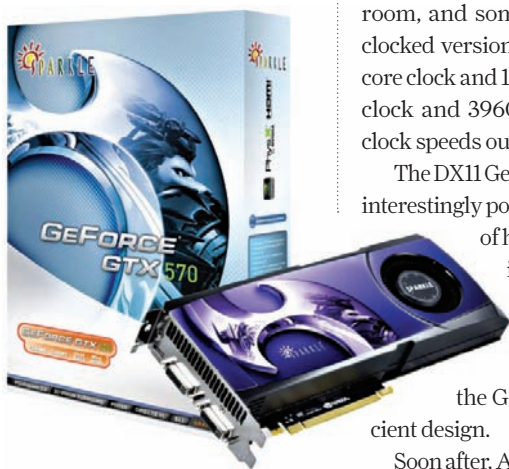
Soon after, AMD brought out

the much awaited Radeon HD 6900 enthusiast series, which incorporates many new architectural and feature changes. For now, the AMD's top offering remains the HD 5970, with the HD 6970 next in the list, officially followed by the HD 6950, the HD 6800 series, and the HD 5700 series. However, the HD 5870 still remains in stock for a while, so if you want one, go get it before they fly off the shelves. The new flagship, HD 6990 – the dual Cayman GPU, was due by the end of December, but now looks like it will launch only in January to replace its fellow dual-GPU AMD flagship - HD 5970 - at the top.

Built on the Southern Islands 40nm Cayman GPU, the HD 6970 (\$369) and HD 6950 (\$299) are built on the 40nm process, after AMD had to abandon the 32nm TSMC node. Until the Northern Islands and the 28nm GPUs come out (and Nvidia with its own 28nm GPUs – including

the GTX 680), it looks like AMD will have to bow to the GTX 580 in single-GPU performance for a while.

So far, the consensus is that the HD 6900 series a serious refresh over the previous generation, with some going so far as to say it has the most architectural and feature improvements in one generation since AMD ATI introduced its first DX10 GPU, the HD 2900. Changes include an integration (finally!) of something akin to Nvidia's multi-sample anti-aliasing, called enhanced quality anti-aliasing; dual graphics engines; 8th generation tessellator; VLIW4 architecture; PowerTune; asynchronous dispatch; better OpenGL and OpenCL support; HDMI 1.4a and DisplayPort 1.2 support; 2GB GDDR5 RAM; improved Local Data Store fetching and new dual bidirectional DMA engine; new improved render back-ends; BIOS toggle switch; and a Unified Video Decoder 3 (UVD3). **d**



Microsoft brings controller-free Kinect for Xbox 360

Microsoft has launched the Kinect for Xbox 360 in India, priced at ₹9,990 for the stand-alone Kinect sensor, bundled with the Kinect Adventures game suite. For those who don't own an Xbox 360 console already, Microsoft has also released a console bundle for an MSRP of ₹22,990 (roughly what the Xbox 360 250GB console is available for), which includes an Xbox 360 4GB console, a Kinect sensor, and Kinect Adventures.

Microsoft's Jaspreet Bindra,

the head of the Entertainment and Devices Division in India, emphasized how the Kinect and its Natural User Interface (NUI) would transform the Indian living room, and "remove the last barrier between the user and the machine."

The Kinect controller-free interface was hailed by Bindra as especially suitable for the Indian environment – apparently we Indians "use gestures a lot", and are a very social bunch, with games no less social for us than a tea party. The intention is to bring people together



in the living room with a new kind of social video gaming. The Kinect was first launched overseas and its implications as a video game/user interface controller have already been much discussed across the world. Bindra clarified the Kinect's position in a hardcore gamer's

arsenal, saying that "core gamers" will probably stick with the Xbox 360 wireless controllers for such games as Gears of War, Fable 3, etc., while the Kinect will open up the world of modern video gaming, living room and Xbox Live competition to the casual, social gamer. **d**